

ENTERPRISE  SUMMIT

From Fire Drill to Operating Model

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From Fire Drill to Operating Model

*What happens after the AI emergency, when the whole business
has to keep the speed*

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NRC Health

The Power of Human Understanding®

Founded in 1981 and publicly traded on NASDAQ (NRC), NRC Health generates ~\$143M in annual revenue with approximately 425 employees. For over four decades, NRC Health has led the charge to personalize healthcare, helping leading health systems understand each unique individual they serve.

45

Years in Healthcare (Est. 1981)

10k+

Partner Organizations

#1

Best in KLAS 2026

Human Understanding®

Empathic, patient-first approach transforming healthcare experiences

Market Leadership

Largest syndicated healthcare consumer research platform in the nation

Proven Innovation

First to deploy real-time PX surveys, discharge calls & AI-powered insights



The Team

- Dustin Warner, Director of Engineering
- 30 engineers and managers
- Market Insights & Consumer Insights products
- 3 product lines

The emergency

The platform our flagship product runs on was bought by a competitor.

Renewal was in question

and we are not signing it

A top-3 revenue product

stops working if we don't replace it

3 people · ~90 days

AI-first, to rebuild the core platform

Nobody argued about process. Everyone knew what was at stake.



Then the fire went out.

**How do we keep the urgency
without the emergency?**

Continual outcomes, not just when there's a fire.

The November binder

7 months

of discussions, documents and handoffs



1 week

with the right people in one room

**produced more than the
previous seven months**

"This is not working."

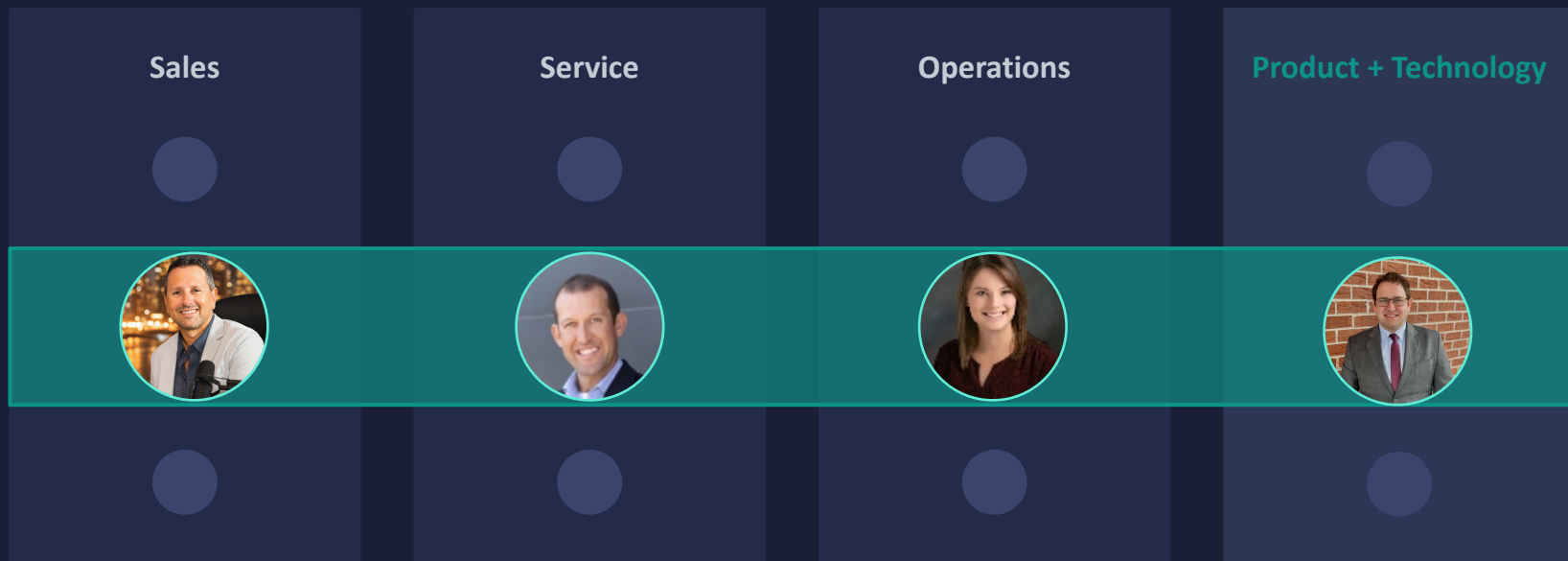
A synthetic org chart



David · EVP, NRC Health

Listen for: what he refused to do

MISO: the synthetic org chart



Same org chart. Everyone went from several products to one — and for this product, product and technology are now one team.

What we needed from each seat

Sales

Brought the pipeline. Ideas that were sold but may not exist yet. Brought visibility to the key features that would close the deal.

Service

Identified partners willing to beta test. Daily stories from our clients on what was working and what was not. How could we increase satisfaction and partner joy when working in our platform.

Operations

The revealed real workflow, not the documented one. Showed what it took to get a customer up and running all of the small manual adjustments required for every customer. What it took to keep the lights on and data relevant.

Product + Tech

Decisions in days, not sprints. Bring ideas not just problems or concerns. Quick prototyping for feasibility and expectations.

Every ask was for time they didn't have, for a product that didn't exist yet.

In their words

“

“Their speed, flexibility, and collaborative approach have fundamentally exceeded my expectations for what’s possible on a project like this.”

Heather

Customer Research Manager

“

The AI First approach has allowed us to quickly develop and test new features within days which creates more efficiencies within Customer Success and in turn a faster and better experience for our partners

Ryan

VP Customer Strategy

The people who used to receive the work now help shape it.

ONE OF FIVE PRODUCT GOALS THE GROUP AGREED ON

“How will our IT investment
improve margin and growth?”

Obvious in this room. Nobody was saying it in our halls.

Systems, not spreadsheets.

If the number lives in someone's spreadsheet, nobody else can see it — and
AI can't use it.

CLIP 2

Why it took an emergency



David · EVP, NRC Health

Listen for: where the creativity was going

Emergency mode vs. how we work now

	EMERGENCY MODE	OPERATING MODEL
Why we move	A crisis forces it	Product goals pull it
Who is in the room	The CEO, for a while	A standing cross-functional community
How tech is seen	An IT project	Inside every solution
Where creativity goes	Into the workaround	Into the solution
What we measure	Did it ship?	Margin and growth

When the crisis ends, the goals have to keep people moving.

Speed became the expectation

2.5 weeks

A SQL 2002 upgrade that had failed twice and had a year of effort in it

6 months → 4 hours

What used to be a funded project is now an afternoon

4-hour hackathons

With the business — ops built Snowflake Cortex skills for custom studies

“You built the whole platform in 90 days. Why would this take six months?”

Nobody funds a project for it any more. It's just how we work.

What we kept from the fire

1

Working software is the meeting

Need → prototype → observe
→ decide → iterate. People
react to something real by day
two.

2

Five teams of three

Small teams make ownership
visible. There is nowhere for a
decision to hide.

3

Build three, throw two away

For reversible decisions, proving
an option is now cheaper than
debating it.

What changed: the whole business is now in the feedback loop, not just engineering.

What I ask of my managers now

1 Build with the team

A manager who can't demo the product can't lead this work.

2 Remove waiting, don't report status

If the team is blocked, unblocking it is the job.

3 Bring a prototype, not an update

Working software ends arguments that documents extend.

4 Ask what we learned

Not how many stories closed. Learning is the unit of progress.

"I'll get back to you in two weeks" is the red flag — two weeks with no learning in them.

“The expectation is AI inside, as opposed to the exception.”

David, EVP, NRC Health

NOW

Content

A clearer NRC voice than ever

NEXT

Analytics

Telling the story the data is
telling

ALWAYS

The business of business

What can be automated, will be

Where we actually are



We didn't wait for structure

No approval, no product owner, no engineering manager. We started and filled it in as we went.



It's volunteers

No reorg behind it. People opt in, and that has limits.



We're finding real problems

The synthetic org is not self-sustaining yet.

“Technology and AI is in everything we do. That’s still an aspirational statement, but I think we’re getting there pretty quick.”

David, EVP, NRC Health

You don't need a reorg to start. We didn't have one.

What I haven't solved

Volunteers don't scale

The synthetic org works because people opt in. What happens when the next product needs one?

Product and technology merged — now what?

If they're one team, what is the product role becoming? I don't have a clean answer.

Adoption is still the slow burn

We build in days and still onboard clients in months.

If you've solved any of these, find me at the break.

The emergency showed us what was possible.

Now we're learning to work that way
without needing an emergency.



Dustin Warner | Director of Software Engineering, NRC Health

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